Modelling and Parameter Estimation of Diesel Engine Aftertreatment System under Catalyst Saturation for Aging Diagnostics

Sesha Charla * **Peter H. Meckl** **,[1] **Bin Yao** ***

* *School of Mechanical Engineering, Purdue University, West Lafayette, Indiana, USA (e-mail: scharla@purdue.edu)*
** *School of Mechanical Engineering, Purdue University, West Lafayette, Indiana, USA (e-mail: meckl@purdue.edu)*
*** *School of Mechanical Engineering, Purdue University, West Lafayette, Indiana, USA (e-mail: byao@purdue.edu)*

Abstract: The present work develops a dynamic model for NO_x reduction in diesel engine SCR systems when the catalyst is saturated with ammonia while explicitly considering the interplay between the residence time and the sampling frequency of the sensors. A novel parameter estimation algorithm is proposed that utilizes the relationship between actual NO_x reduction and predicted NO_x reduction under saturation in the system while explicitly considering uncertainties due to NO_x sensor cross-sensitivity. Further, the model parameters are shown to be sensitive to the catalyst's aging state. Using the parameter estimates and their statistics, a hypothesis-testing framework based on the Wald test is developed to detect catalyst aging. The performance of the proposed aging detector is demonstrated using both test-cell data at different aging levels and real-world data from four long-haul trucks.

Keywords: Diesel Engine Aftertreatment System, System Identification, Nonlinear Systems, Hybrid Systems, Diagnostics, Parameter Estimation, Linear Programming

1. INTRODUCTION

Diesel engine aftertreatment systems reduce the concentrations of harmful gases such as NO_x and CO from exhaust emissions. The Selective Catalytic Reduction (SCR) system reduces the engine-out NO_x to N_2 and H_2O using ammonia from urea dosing in the presence of a catalyst. This catalytic conversion process is regulated to decrease the levels of ammonia in the exhaust (ammonia slip) via two methods. The first is feedback control, which adjusts the urea injection rate based on the exhaust NO_x concentrations. The second method involves an additional catalytic reaction, the Ammonia Slip Catalyst (ASC), which is designed to oxidize any excess ammonia at the end of the SCR bed. Figure-1 shows a schematic of the SCR-ASC system. It has been found that the NO_x-reduction capacity of the catalyst decreases over time due to hydrothermal aging and deposition of contaminants such as excess urea, platinum, sulfur and phosphorus (Matsumoto et al., 2016). The aging of the catalyst leads to increased emissions of NO_x and ammonia slip, which can result in non-compliance with environmental regulations. A fault detection system for catalyst aging would provide better control over system maintenance and improve the overall reduction in emissions.

Thus, modern diesel aftertreatment systems, particularly those that integrate Selective Catalytic Reduction (SCR) with Ammonia Slip Catalyst (ASC), necessitate advanced onboard diagnostics (OBD) tools for accurate assessment of catalyst aging. However, the effectiveness of traditional OBD approaches for this purpose has been impeded by the absence of model validation with real-world catalyst degradation data, the limitations imposed by existing commercial NO_x sensors' cross-sensitivity to ammonia, and the absence of ammonia sensors in commercial vehicles.

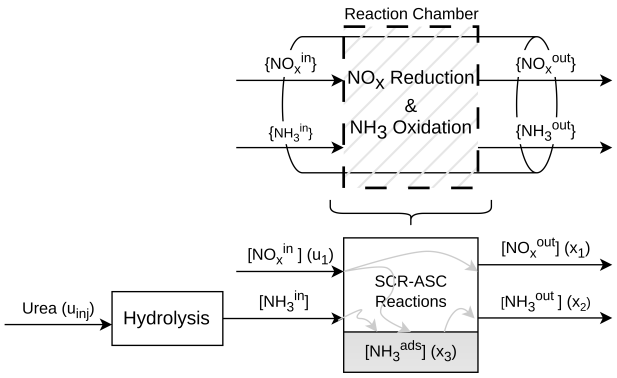


Fig. 1. Schematic of the SCR-ASC system

Numerous studies have been conducted on modeling SCR-ASC systems and their control (Yuan et al., 2015). A prevalent modeling approach is to approximate the PDE model for the plug flow reaction as a set of ODEs using a sequence of Continuously Stirred Tank Reactors (CSTRs) approximation (Hsieh and Wang 2011, and Hsieh and Wang 2014). The single CSTR approach was first justified in Devarakonda et al. (2008) and a nonlinear

[1] Corresponding author.

model was developed using these assumptions, which was then linearized for feedback control design (Devarakonda et al., 2009). With this model, observers were designed to estimate the states corresponding to the catalyst's storage (Ma and Wang, 2017; Jain et al., 2020). A method for detecting the catalyst's aging using an observer for the change in the maximum storage capacity of the catalyst, modeled as an exponential function of temperature, was also proposed in Ma and Wang (2017) and Jiang et al. (2019). Alternatively, an onboard diagnostics (OBD) logic for catalyst aging based on the tailpipe NO_x and ammonia is proposed in Matsumoto et al. (2016) based on the hypothesis of reduction in adsorption sites and demonstrated on real-world trucks. A common theme in these studies is that the system identification results in a non-convex, nonlinear parameter estimation problem. Moreover, these studies assume the availability of all the gaseous states at the tailpipe for state estimation and to eliminate the effects of cross-sensitivity of the NO_x sensors, which is not always the case in real-world applications as tailpipe ammonia measurements are not generally available in commercial vehicles. Another fundamental issue with the CSTR model in the context of sensor sampling is that the discretization of the continuous model does not account for the residence time of the reactants, resulting in high sampling frequency requirements that are not feasible in practice. Additionally, the discretization requires at least two CSTRs to capture the system dynamics and causality (Charla et al., 2024), thereby increasing the model order.

An alternative approach to the problem would be discarding the CSTR assumption and modelling the time evolution of the sensor signals when a "plug" or "parcel" of the exhaust gases flows through the chamber in discrete time, considering the interplay between sampling and residence time of the reactants. The catalyst saturation that is inherently considered in the CSTR approach needs to be explicitly included as a separate mode of the system. The present work develops such a model under catalyst saturation which becomes one of the modes of the complete switched nonlinear model. Following the model development, we present the parameter estimation algorithm that estimates the parameters of the saturated catalyst model using real-world data whose operating mode is unknown and that have additional uncertainties due to NO_x sensor cross-sensitivity to ammonia. Finally, we develop a statistical test for detecting catalyst aging based on the estimated parameters of the saturated catalyst model. The performance of the proposed aging detector is demonstrated using both test-cell and real-world truck data.

2. SCR-ASC SYSTEM DYNAMICS UNDER CATALYST SATURATION

The SCR-ASC subsystem in the diesel engine aftertreatment systems involves reacting flow over a catalyst that adsorbs ammonia from urea decomposition. The reaction kinetics start with the decomposition of urea into ammonia followed by its adsorption onto the surface of the catalyst. The NO_x entering the chamber is reduced by this adsorbed ammonia. The Eley-Rideal reaction mechanism (Prins, 2018), (Yuan et al., 2015), (Hsieh and Wang, 2011), (Hsieh and Wang, 2014) is considered for modeling the SCR reaction kinetics, where one reactant (NO_x) is gaseous, and the other is adsorbed on the catalyst surface (NH_3). Hsieh and Wang (2014) lists all the reactions that take place inside the SCR-ASC chamber. Ammonia oxidation (AMOX) happens on the surfaces of both the SCR and the ASC catalysts, but the SCR catalyst favors NO_x reduction while the ASC is specifically designed for ammonia oxidation. In order to keep the model order reasonably low and parameters identifiable, only the following three prominent reactions (Devarakonda et al., 2008),(Hsieh and Wang, 2011) are considered:

(1) Standard SCR reaction:

$$4NH_3^{ads} + 4NO + O_2 \xrightarrow{k_{scr}} 4N_2 + 6H_2O \quad (1)$$

(2) Ammonia Oxidation:

$$4NH_3^{ads} + 3O_2 \xrightarrow{k_{oxi}} 2N_2 + 6H_2O \quad (2)$$

(3) Ammonia Adsorption/Desorption:

$$NH_3 + \Theta_{free} \underset{k_{des}}{\overset{k_{ads}}{\rightleftharpoons}} NH_3^{ads} \quad (3)$$

This aggregation of reactions results in errors in parameter estimates; specifically, parameters containing the rate constant for the NO_x reduction (k_{scr}) have higher (bounded) uncertainty because they become dependent on the nitrogen selectivity of the AMOX reaction (Jain et al., 2023). Considering the reaction chamber as a control volume

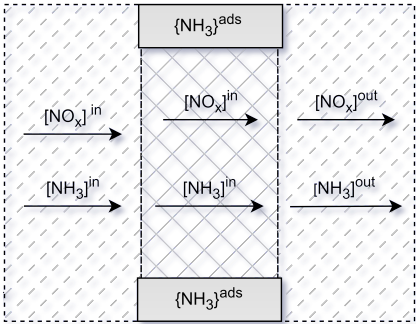


Fig. 2. Control volume in plug flow reaction

(Figure-2), the dynamic model is developed based on the molar conservation of species at the inlet and outlet separated by a residence-time interval. By assuming a zero-order hold on the inlet species over the sampling time, the equations relating inlet and outlet concentrations at the residence-time scale are extended to the sampling-time scale. The residence time can be parameterized as a function of mass flow rate (F) assuming that the effect of the density variation on residence time is insignificant:

$$\tau(k) = \frac{\rho V_{scr}}{F(k)} = \frac{\tau_0}{F(k)} \quad (4)$$

Let $\{\bullet\}$ be the number of moles and $[\bullet]$ be the concentration of a given species $\bullet$. We have the molar conservation of NO_x across the control volume (V_{scr}) within one residence time (τ):

$$\{NO_x\}^{out}(t + (i+1)\tau) = \{NO_x\}^{in}(t + i\tau) + V_{scr}\int_0^{\tau} \frac{d}{dt}[NO_x]^{scr} dt \quad (5)$$

The number of moles entering at the inlet and leaving at the outlet can be written as a function of the concentration, residence time, and mass flow rate (F):

$$\{NO_x\}^{in/out} = [NO_x]^{in/out}\tau\left(\frac{F}{\rho}\right) = [NO_x]^{in/out}V_{scr} \tag{6}$$

Using the Eley-Rideal mechanism for the standard SCR reaction (1):

$$\frac{d}{dt}[NO_x]^{scr}dt = -k_{scr}[NH_3]^{ads}[NO_x]^{in} \tag{7}$$

Rewriting (5) in terms of concentrations and integrating over the residence time:

$$[NO_x]^{out}(t+(i+1)\tau) = [NO_x]^{in}(t+i\tau) - \tau k_{scr}[NH_3]^{ads}[NO_x]^{in} \tag{8}$$

Summing the equations from (8) for $i = 0$ to $n-1$, where n is the total number of residence times within one sampling period ($n = t_s/\tau$) and using the zero-order hold assumptions at the inlet (9) and outlet (10) concentrations, we obtain (11).

$$[NO_x]^{in}(t+i\tau) = [NO_x]^{in}(t) \quad \forall i \in [0, n-1] \tag{9}$$

$$[NO_x]^{out}(t+(i+1)\tau) = [NO_x]^{out}(t+t_s) \quad \forall i \in [0, n-1] \tag{10}$$

Letting tailpipe NO_x concentration be $x_1(k+1) = [NO_x]^{out}(t+t_s)$ and inlet NO_x concentration be $u_1(k) = [NO_x]^{in}(t)$, we get,

$$\underbrace{[NO_x]^{out}(t+t_s)}_{x_1(k+1)} = \underbrace{[NO_x]^{in}(t)}_{u_1(k)} - \tau(t)k_{scr}(t)[NO_x]^{in}(t)\underbrace{\left\{\frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=0}^{n-1}[NH_3]^{ads}(t+i\tau)\right\}}_{\gamma(k)} \tag{11}$$

The quantity $\gamma(k)$ is the average concentration of ammonia adsorbed on the catalyst's surface across the n residence times between k and $k+1$ samples. $\gamma(k)$ is bounded by the total concentration of voids on the surface of the catalyst, Γ, which decreases with increasing temperature.

$$0 \le \gamma(k) \le \Gamma \qquad \forall k \tag{12}$$

The unbounded dynamics of γ, $\gamma^{ub}(k)$ are a nonlinear function dependent on the concentration of adsorbed ammonia, urea dosing (u_{inj}), and the inlet NO_x concentration from the previous time step.

$$\gamma^{ub}(k) = g_\gamma\left(\gamma(k-1), u_{inj}(k-1), [NO_x]^{in}(k-1)\right) \tag{13}$$

The actual expression, which is beyond the scope of this work, can be derived using a similar approach to that used to derive NO_x process dynamics (11). $\gamma(k)$ can be described using the following piecewise function:

$$\gamma(k) = \begin{cases} \gamma^{ub}(k) & \text{if} \quad 0 \le \gamma^{ub}(k) \le \Gamma \\ \Gamma & \text{if} \quad \gamma^{ub}(k) > \Gamma \qquad \text{[Saturation]} \\ 0 & \text{if} \quad \gamma^{ub}(k) < 0 \qquad \text{[Empty]} \end{cases} \tag{14}$$

Let $\eta(k)$ be the NO_x reduction during a given time step k,

$$\eta(k+1) = u_1(k) - x_1(k+1) \tag{15}$$

Introducing the above definition and the residence time expression (4) into the NO_x process dynamics model (11), we get,

$$\eta(k+1) = \frac{u_1(k)}{F(k)}\tau_0\ k_{scr}(T(k))\ \gamma(T(k)) \tag{16}$$

For NO_x process dynamics under catalyst saturation, $\gamma(k) = \Gamma$.

$$\implies \eta_{sat}(k+1) = \frac{u_1(k)}{F(k)}\tau_0\ k_{scr}(T(k))\ \Gamma(T(k)) \tag{17}$$

The above equation (17) shows that the tailpipe NO_x concentration becomes independent of urea dosing under catalyst saturation. Polynomial approximations of Arrhenius temperature dependence of the rate constant, k_{scr} and the concentration of viable voids, Γ (Hsieh and Wang, 2014; Ciardelli et al., 2004; Joo et al., 2008), are used to get a linear-in-parameters model for the NO_x process dynamics.

$$k_{scr}(T) = A_{scr}e^{\left(-\frac{E_{scr}}{RT}\right)} \approx \sum k_i T^i \qquad i = 0, 1, \ldots \tag{18}$$

$$\Gamma(T) = S_1 e^{-S_2 T} \approx \sum r_i T^i \qquad i = 0, 1, \ldots \tag{19}$$

The above approximate models for temperature dependence introduce parameter estimates that depend on temperature ranges in the samples. For numerical stability (Press et al., 2003), the given temperature range is mapped to $[-1, 1]$ and Chebyshev polynomial bases (Trefethen, 2019) are used instead of standard polynomials. Incorporating equations (4) and (19) into the NO_x process dynamics model (17),

$$\eta_{sat}(k+1) = \phi_{sat}^T(T(k))\ \theta_{sat} \tag{20}$$

$$\phi_{sat}(k) = \frac{u_1(k)}{F(k)}\left[2\left(\frac{T-T_0}{T_r}\right)^2 - 1\ \ \frac{T-T_0}{T_r}\ \ 1\right] \tag{21}$$

$$\text{where} \quad T_0 = \frac{T_{max}+T_{min}}{2}, \quad T_r = \frac{T_{max}-T_{min}}{2}$$

It can be observed that in a given time step, the maximum NO_x reduction occurs when the catalyst is saturated. Thus, under the same temperature, flow rate and inlet NO_x concentration, the response of the saturated model (17) forms a tight upper bound to the response of the actual system, which switches between saturation and desaturation based on urea dosing, flow rate and catalyst temperature. This results in the following bounding condition on the response of the saturated system:

$$\eta_{sat}(k) \ge \eta(k) \qquad \forall k \tag{22}$$

This relationship is used for model parameter estimation.

2.1 NO_x sensor cross-sensitivity

Commercial NO_x sensors are cross-sensitive to tailpipe ammonia. Figure 3 shows the effect of cross-sensitivity on commercial NO_x sensors due to tailpipe ammonia. When the tailpipe ammonia is greater than a threshold value, the NO_x sensor output is corrupted, as shown in the plots where the NO_x sensor measurement is significantly higher than the FTIR measurement, which can be considered the true value. The resulting error is modeled as a function of ammonia concentration and a temperature-dependent cross-sensitivity factor $\chi(T)$. This introduces a non-negative directional error ($\varepsilon_\chi = \chi(T(k)) \times [NH_3]^{out} \ge 0$) into the tailpipe NO_x measurement y_1. Accordingly, when the NO_x reduction in a time step is calculated from sensor measurements, $y_1(k) = x_1(k) + \varepsilon_\chi(k)$, the estimated quantity is less than the actual NO_x reduction:

$$\eta_y(k) = u_1(k-1) - y_1(k) = \eta(k) - \varepsilon_\chi(k) \leq \eta(k) \quad (23)$$

Thus, the bounding condition on the saturated system's response (22) remains valid when the NO_x reduction during the time step is estimated from the NO_x sensor measurements:

$$\eta_{sat}(k) \geq \eta(k) = \eta_y(k) + \varepsilon_\chi(k) \geq \eta_y(k) \quad (24)$$

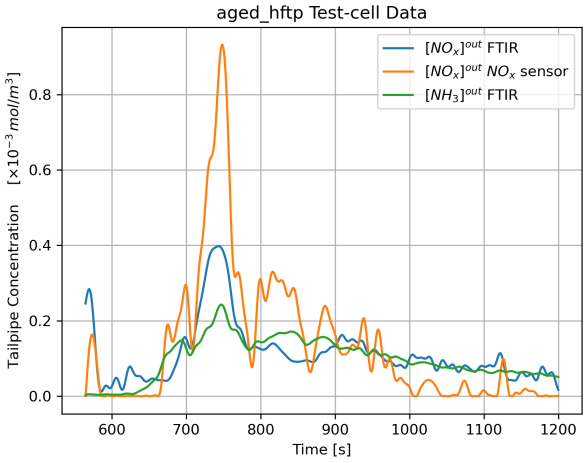


Fig. 3. NO_x sensor cross-sensitivity to tailpipe ammonia

3. MAXIMUM LIKELIHOOD ESTIMATION OF THE MODEL PARAMETERS

The catalyst switches between saturation mode and normal mode based on states that are not completely controllable experimentally. The bounding condition on the saturated system's response (22) can be used for detecting segments of the data where the catalyst's operation is normal or saturated. As the saturated catalyst's response forms a tight upper bound to the actual system's response, the parameters of the system will be the solution to the linear programming problem that minimizes the area under the curve with the lower bound as the response of the actual system:

$$\text{min.} \sum \eta_{sat}(k) \quad \text{s.t} \quad (\eta_{sat}(k) \geq \eta(k)) \quad \forall k \quad (25)$$

The optimization problem (25) is feasible as η_{sat} and $\eta \geq 0$ always. When the NO_x sensor data is used, $\eta(k)$ is replaced with $\eta_y(k)$ as the bounding condition still holds (24) . Rewriting the optimization problem using the regression vector (20), we have the linear programming problem for estimating the parameters of the catalyst:

$$\begin{aligned} &\text{minimize} && \mathbf{1}^T [\Phi_{sat}\theta_{sat}] \quad (26)\\ &\text{subject to} && \Phi_{sat}\theta_{sat} \succeq H, \\ &\text{where} && \Phi_{sat} = [\phi_{sat}(1), \phi_{sat}(2), \ldots, \phi_{sat}(N-1)]^T \\ & && H = [\eta(2), \eta(3), \ldots, \eta(N)]^T \end{aligned}$$

$\mathbf{1}$ is a column vector of $1's$.

The above estimate of θ_{sat} is the maximum likelihood estimate (MLE) under a half-normal distribution (Kay, 1993; Trump, 2001) for model structure error, (ε_η), between the saturated system's response, $\eta_{sat}(k)$, and the actual response of the catalyst, $\eta(k)$ (Appendix-A). In the case of NO_x-sensor data with cross-sensitivity, the model structure error includes the cross-sensitivity error ε_χ and is assumed to be a half-normal random variable.

Using asymptotic properties of MLE (Theorem-7.3 in Kay (1993)), with sufficiently large data length (N), the parameter estimate $\hat{\theta}_{sat}$ asymptotically follows a normal distribution under some regularity conditions on the PDF $p(\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_n; \theta_{sat})$,

$$\hat{\theta}_{sat} \sim \mathcal{N}\left(\theta_{sat}, I^{-1}(\theta_{sat})\right) \quad (27)$$

where $I(\theta_{sat})$ is the Fisher information matrix evaluated at the true value of the parameter (θ_{sat}). The regularity conditions require the existence of derivatives of the log-likelihood function and the Fisher information being nonzero. Using the log-likelihood function, $L(\theta_{sat})$, for half-normal distribution (A.4), we have,

$$\begin{aligned} [I(\theta_{sat})]_{ij} &= -E\left[\frac{\partial^2 L(\theta_{sat})}{\partial\theta_j \partial\theta_i}\right] = \frac{1}{\sigma^2}\sum_{k=1}^{N} \frac{\partial\varepsilon_\eta(k)}{\partial\theta_i}\frac{\partial\varepsilon_\eta(k)}{\partial\theta_j} \\ I(\theta_{sat}) &= \frac{1}{\sigma^2}\left[\Phi_{sat}^T \Phi_{sat}\right] \quad (28) \end{aligned}$$

The variance in the η_{sat} prediction for the given time-step is obtained by propagating the uncertainty of parameter estimates (27). Using (20), we have,

$$\text{Var}\left[\eta_{sat}(k)\right] = \phi_{sat}(k)^T I^{-1}(\theta_{sat})\phi_{sat}(k) \quad (29)$$

The parameter estimates using FTIR measurements from the test-cell experiments are tabulated in Table-1. The parameters show consistency across repeated RMC (Ramped Mode Cycle) and Hot-FTP (Federal Test Procedure) tests on the same catalyst, which validates the estimation approach. However, the parameters vary significantly between RMC and Hot-FTP tests. This is predominantly due to the differences in the temperature ranges experienced by the catalyst during the tests, which affect the Arrhenius temperature dependence of the rate constant and the concentration of viable voids on the catalyst surface. The temperature range of the data considered during the RMC tests is between 240°C and 360°C, while for the Hot-FTP tests it is between 200°C and 300°C.

Table 1. Parameter Estimates using FTIR Data

Test	$\hat{\theta}_1$	$\hat{\theta}_2$	$\hat{\theta}_3$	σ
DG RMC 1	-0.63	0.55	38.74	1.14
DG RMC 2	-0.82	0.69	38.61	1.08
DG RMC 3	-0.80	1.12	38.78	1.10
Aged RMC	-1.31	1.89	36.94	1.01
DG Hot FTP 1	-2.14	-5.80	39.53	1.35
DG Hot FTP 2	-3.45	-7.99	38.05	1.30
DG Hot FTP 3	-3.37	-6.42	38.88	1.33
Aged Hot FTP	-4.54	-8.01	37.00	1.31

The parameter estimates using NO_x sensor measurements from the test-cell experiments are tabulated in Table-2. The parameter estimates are different from those obtained using FTIR measurements (Table-1) due to the cross-sensitivity of the NO_x sensor to ammonia. However, the parameters show consistency across repeated tests on the same catalyst under similar test conditions. The NO_x sensor cross-sensitivity error $\varepsilon_\chi(T)$ introduces bias in the parameter estimates as part of the error that has the same

temperature dependence as the model structure enters into the parameter estimates. Thus, the linear programming problem estimates the parameters with an added bias term as shown below:

$$\varepsilon_\chi(T) = \phi_{sat}(T(k))^T \theta_{\varepsilon_\chi} + \Delta\varepsilon_\chi \tag{30}$$

$$J(\theta_{sat}) = \sum_{k=0}^{N-1} \left(\phi^T(k)\left(\theta_{sat} + \theta_{\varepsilon_\chi}\right) - \eta(k)\right) \tag{31}$$

Thus, the estimated parameters using NO_x sensor measurements will have a bias dependent on the cross-sensitivity error characteristics of the sensor used. From the experimental results, it is observed that NO_x sensor cross-sensitivity reduces the difference between the estimates of aging factor (Figure 6, 7) between aged and degreened catalysts. But the overall trend of change in parameter values remains consistent.

Table 2. Parameter Estimates using NO_x Sensor Data

Test	$\hat{\theta}_1$	$\hat{\theta}_2$	$\hat{\theta}_3$	σ
DG RMC 1	-0.70	0.56	38.48	1.10
DG RMC 2	-1.18	0.93	38.43	1.07
DG RMC 3	-0.54	0.62	38.99	1.06
Aged RMC	-1.03	1.26	37.80	1.00
DG Hot FTP 1	-2.30	-6.11	37.08	1.28
DG Hot FTP 2	-2.71	-6.13	36.22	1.27
DG Hot FTP 3	-3.92	-6.17	35.81	1.30
Aged Hot FTP	-6.42	-13.06	34.73	1.34

Furthermore, the above delineated parameter estimation method has a limitation that the data set must have response of the catalyst under saturation for some finite duration. If this condition is not met, the algorithm estimates the parameters considering the maximum concentration of adsorbed ammonia as the concentration corresponding to catalyst saturation (Appendix-B).

4. CATALYST MODE DETECTION

The saturated catalyst model's response does not depend on the previous state but only on the inputs, making the response independent of the initial conditions. Thus, using the parameter estimates, a given data point can be classified as a saturated-catalyst response if the prediction error for the same inputs (inlet NO_x, u_1, and mass flow rate, F) is less than ϵ_{sat}.

$$|\hat{\eta}_{sat}(k) - \eta(k)| \leq \epsilon_{sat} \implies \text{Catalyst Saturation} \tag{32}$$

For the current test-cell and truck data set, $\epsilon_{sat} = 2.5 \times 10^{-3}\, mol/m^{-3}$. This value is chosen based on the variance of the distribution of the prediction error for the saturated catalyst model.

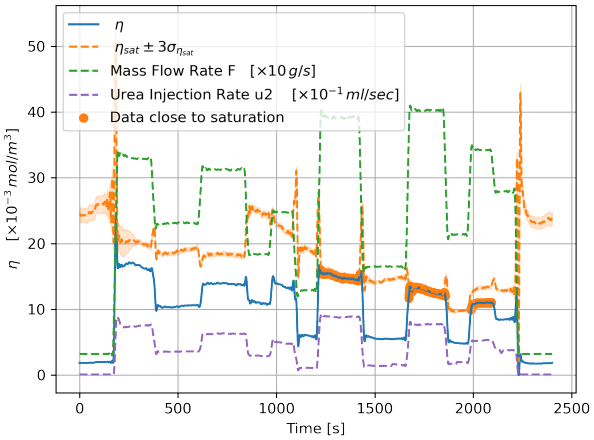


Fig. 4. Catalyst Mode Detection for DG RMC 1 Data

The catalyst mode detection for the degreened (DG) catalyst under RMC 1 test-cell conditions using FTIR measurements is shown in Figure 4. The figure illustrates the operating points for which the prediction error of the saturated catalyst model satisfies (32), and that are therefore classified as saturated, i.e., close to maximum NO_x reduction. The catalyst is found to be close to saturation when the mass flow rate and the urea dosing rates are high, consistent with the physical understanding of the catalyst operation. Furthermore, the flow rate can introduce a virtual ceiling on the maximum achievable NO_x reduction due to reduced residence time in the catalyst, which would be indistinguishable from saturated-catalyst behavior, since the NO_x reduction would be independent of urea dosing.

A fraction of the data from the test-cell experiments under RMC and Hot-FTP test conditions for both degreened and aged catalysts is found to be in saturated mode. The number of data points close to catalyst saturation (N_{sat}) and the total number of samples (N) for different test conditions are listed in Tables 3 and 4. The total number of data points, N, is the total length of the temporally contiguous segment of the test cell data that is within the chosen temperature operating range for the tests. The operating range for RMC test is between $250°C$ and $350°C$, and for Hot-FTP test is between $200°C$ and $300°C$. Note that the higher number of

Table 3. Data Points Close to Catalyst Saturation in Test-Cell FTIR Data

Test	N	N_{sat}
DG RMC 1	2402	490
DG RMC 2	2402	493
DG RMC 3	2402	491
Aged RMC	2402	515
DG Hot FTP 1	634	186
DG Hot FTP 2	634	181
DG Hot FTP 3	638	180
Aged Hot FTP	636	198

data points classified as close to catalyst saturation in RMC test conditions, compared to Hot-FTP, results in

Table 4. Data Points Close to Catalyst Saturation in Test-Cell NO_x Sensor Data

Test	N	N_{sat}
DG RMC 1	2402	492
DG RMC 2	2402	494
DG RMC 3	2402	493
Aged RMC	2402	515
DG Hot FTP 1	634	194
DG Hot FTP 2	634	191
DG Hot FTP 3	638	198
Aged Hot FTP	636	220

better parameter estimates and performance of the aging detection test statistic in this case (Table 5).

5. MODEL PARAMETERS CAPTURE CATALYST AGING

The parameters of the saturated system are a function of the rate constant for the SCR reaction and the maximum surface concentration of viable voids on the catalyst. The adsorption site concentration is hypothesized to change with aging of the catalyst, allowing the parameters to capture the aging of the catalyst. This is demonstrated using the test-cell experiments on a new (degreened) and hydrothermally aged catalyst with the same capacity. The predicted NO_x reduction for an aged catalyst is found to be statistically lower than the predicted NO_x reduction in a degreened catalyst (Figure 5). The dashed line in Figure 5 corresponds to the actual response of the reference system, whose inputs are used to predict the saturated system's response using parameter estimates from the degreened and aged catalyst data under RMC test conditions. Thus, in accordance with the bounding condition (22), the actual response is always less than the predicted saturated system's response. When the η_{sat}

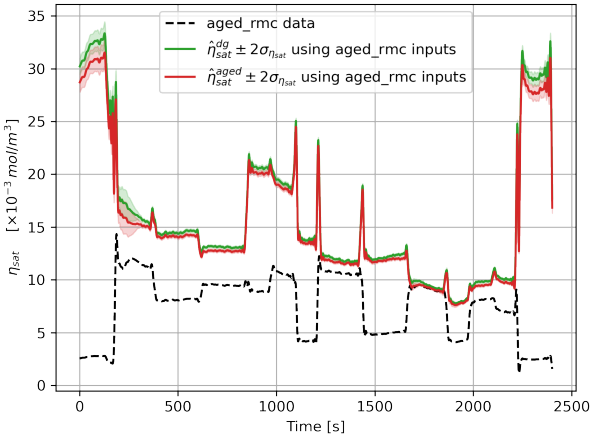


Fig. 5. Predicted η_{sat} for Aged and Degreened Catalyst

response is normalized with respect to the inlet NO_x concentration and flow rate, we obtain a quantity that is only a function of temperature and represents the product of the rate constant and maximum surface coverage. From (20),

$$\alpha_{sat} = \frac{F(k)}{u_1(k)}\eta_{sat}(k) = \tau_0 k_{scr}\Gamma = \phi_T^T(k)\theta_{sat} \tag{33}$$

$$\text{where} \quad \phi_T^T(k) = \left[2\left(\frac{T-T_0}{T_r}\right)^2 - 1 \;\; \frac{T-T_0}{T_r} \;\; 1\right] \tag{34}$$

This quantity α_{sat} can be estimated and changes with aging of the catalyst based on the hypothesis that aging changes the adsorption site concentration. The change in α_{sat} with aging is demonstrated using the test-cell experiments (Figures 6 and 7). The variance is estimated by propagating the variance of the η_{sat} estimate (29). As expected from the cost function for parameter estimation under NO_x sensor cross-sensitivity (31), the parameter estimates have a bias that reduces the difference between the estimates for the degreened and aged catalyst. However, the overall trend of change in parameter values with aging remains consistent across both FTIR and NO_x sensor measurements.

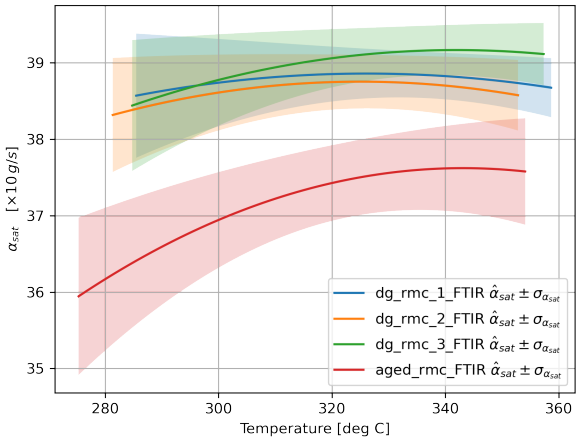


Fig. 6. $\hat{\alpha}_{sat}$ from RMC FTIR Data

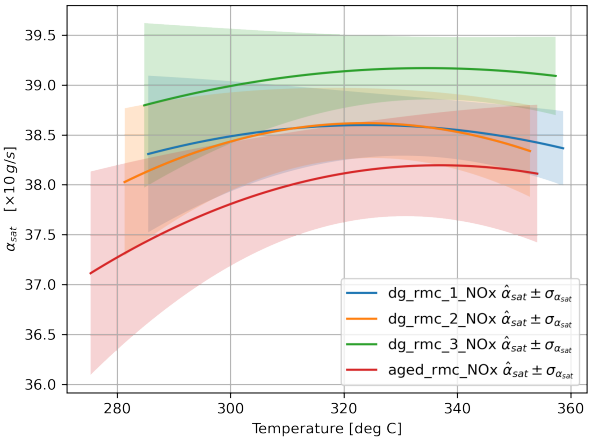


Fig. 7. $\hat{\alpha}_{sat}$ from RMC NO_x Sensor Data

Thus, θ_{sat} captures the aging of the catalyst. Hence, the catalyst aging detection problem can be posed as a hypothesis-testing problem, with the null hypothesis ($\mathcal{H}_0$) corresponding to a degreened catalyst and the alternative

hypothesis ($\mathcal{H}_1$) corresponding to an aged catalyst. Since the distribution of the error is assumed to be known (half-normal) for both hypotheses and differs by the unknown parameter θ_{sat}, which can be estimated, the following Wald test (Wald, 1943) is proposed to check whether the parameter estimates for a given data set correspond to an aged catalyst or a known degreened catalyst. Decide $\mathcal{H}_1$ if,

$$T_w = \left(\hat{\theta}_{sat} - \theta_{sat}^{dg}\right)^T I\left(\hat{\theta}_{sat}\right)\left(\hat{\theta}_{sat} - \theta_{sat}^{dg}\right) > \beta \qquad (35)$$

where θ_{sat}^{dg} is the parameter estimate for the degreened catalyst under the same input conditions, including temperature, flow rate, and urea-dosing rate ranges. The threshold β is chosen based on the experimental results. For the RMC and FTP data sets, the values of the test statistic are tabulated in Table 5. The distribution of the test statistic

Table 5. Wald Test Results on Test-Cell

Test	T_w from FTIR	T_w from NO_x sensor
DG RMC 1	0.26	5.54
DG RMC 2	0.00	0.00
DG RMC 3	6.71	5.46
Aged RMC	47.16	17.68
DG Hot FTP 1	0.49	0.81
DG Hot FTP 2	3.26	1.98
DG Hot FTP 3	0.00	0.00
Aged Hot FTP	4.84	11.44

under aging (non-central χ^2, asymptotically) is different for the RMC and FTP test conditions due to differences in the ranges of inputs (temperature, flow rate, and urea-dosing rate) experienced by the catalyst during the tests. Based on the results, a reasonably discerning threshold that maximizes the probability of detection for both Hot-FTP and RMC test conditions is found to be

$$\beta_{hFTP} = 4.00, \qquad \beta_{RMC} = 10.00 \qquad (36)$$

Further investigation with more data is needed to determine the probabilities of detection and false alarm for these thresholds. The proposed Wald test detects the aged catalyst for both FTIR and NO_x sensor measurements under both test conditions.

6. AGING DETECTION FROM TRUCK DATA

The performance of the proposed aging detector is also demonstrated using the NO_x sensor data from four long-haul trucks. The road data were collected from trucks operating in the United States for two days separated by a few years (Table 6) during which the catalyst has aged based on the existing performance measures. The data contains measurements of NO_x sensors before and after the catalyst, as well as other required variables including flow rate, temperature and urea injection rate. The data preprocessing includes, (1) removing the rows with missing values, (2) removing the rows whose operating temperature range is beyond the range of $200 - 300\,^0C$, (3) interpolating the missing data if the data gaps are smaller than a minute, and finally, (4) smoothing the data using a non-causal Chebyshev filter. The preprocessed data is then partitioned into drive segments with no breaks, which correspond to a continuous driving period from engine start to engine stop. Unlike the test-cell data where the engine drive-cycles are repeatable and produce

Table 6. Truck Data Summary

Truck	Earlier Data Year	Latter Data Year	Mileage Difference
Truck A	2015	2017	2.8×10^5
Truck B	2015	2018	11.9×10^5
Truck C	2015	2017	5.9×10^5
Truck D	2015	2016	6.6×10^5

a significant fraction of samples where the catalyst is close to saturation, the truck data drive segments constitute varied driving conditions with fewer samples $\{\leq 10\%\}$ that are close to catalyst saturation. A necessary condition for the proposed parameter estimation and aging detection framework is that the data contain a sufficiently large number of samples close to catalyst saturation such that the asymptotic properties of the MLE and the test statistic hold (37). Hence, the drive segment data are further pruned to only include segments with at least 150 samples (120 in the case of Truck C) close to catalyst saturation.

$$N_{sat} \geq N_{sat}^{min} \qquad (37)$$

$$\beta_{truck} = 250 \qquad (38)$$

The threshold of the Wald test statistic (38) for aging detection in trucks is chosen such that it maximizes the probability of detection while minimizing the probability of false alarm and missed detection for the given limited truck data. A larger data set would help determine the thresholds using Neyman-Pearson criteria (Kay, 1998). The value of the test statistic for the drive segments for each truck is tabulated in Tables C.1, C.2, C.3 and C.4. A summary of the aging detection results is tabulated in Table 7. The detector performs reasonably well on three

Table 7. Truck Data Aging Detection Results

Truck	Total Drive Segments	Detection	False Alarm	Missed Detection
Truck A	8	4	0	4
Truck B	11	9	1	1
Truck C	9	7	1	1
Truck D	8	6	2	0

of the four trucks with high probability of detection and low false alarm and missed detection rates. Truck A has relatively lower mileage difference between the earlier and latter data years which may explain the lower detection performance. The performance is limited by the amount of data available with sufficient samples close to catalyst saturation. Further, the lack of ground truth on the actual individual catalyst's aging levels limits the ability to quantify the performance of the detector. Nevertheless, the results demonstrate the potential of the proposed aging detection framework for onboard application using NO_x sensor data.

7. CONCLUSION

The dynamics of NO_x reduction in diesel engine SCR systems under catalyst saturation were used to develop an aging detector based on the hypothesis that the model parameters associated with catalyst storage capacity change as the catalyst ages. A dynamic model for NO_x reduction under saturation was formulated from molar conservation while explicitly accounting for the interplay between the

residence time of the reacting flow and the sampling time of the sensors. A maximum-likelihood parameter estimation algorithm was proposed using the bounding condition between the actual system response and the response under catalyst saturation. The algorithm was validated using experimental test-cell data under RMC and Hot-FTP conditions. The NO_x-sensor's ammonia cross-sensitivity was shown to introduce a bias in the parameter estimates, reducing the separation between the estimates for degreened and aged catalysts. A hypothesis-testing framework based on the Wald test was then developed for catalyst aging detection using the estimated parameters. The detector's performance was demonstrated using test-cell data at different aging levels and real-world data from four long-haul trucks. The results indicate that the proposed framework can reliably identify catalyst aging even in the presence of sensor cross-sensitivity and varying operating conditions, provided that the data include a sufficient number of samples near the saturation regime, which forms a necessary condition for aging detection.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Authors acknowledge the support and feedback from David Schmidt, Larry Bruner, Adam Kidd and Tom Nelson of Cummins, Inc. Authors acknowledge the funding and test-cell, truck and simulation data of Diesel Engine Aftertreatment Systems from Cummins, Inc.

NOMENCLATURE

Symbols:

$\{\bullet\}$	Number of moles of $\bullet$. $(moles)$
$[\bullet]$	Concentration of $\bullet$. (mol/m^3)
A_{scr}	Pre-exponential factor of SCR reaction
E_{scr}	Activation Energy of SCR reaction
F	Mass flow rate of the exhaust gases (g/s)
$I(\theta)$	Fisher Information Matrix
k_i	Coefficients of polynomial temperature model for k_{scr}
N_{sat}	Number of data points close to catalyst saturation
N	Total number of data points
N_{sat}^{min}	Minimum number of data points close to catalyst saturation for reliable parameter estimation
r_i	Coefficients of polynomial temperature model for Γ
R	Universal gas constant
S_1, S_2	Coefficients of the temperature model for Γ, $S_1, S_2 \geq 0$
T	Temperature
T_w	Wald test statistic for catalyst aging detection
u_1	Engine-out (SCR-in) NO_x concentration
V_{scr}	Volume of the catalyst chamber
x_1	Tailpipe (SCR-out) NO_x concentration
y_1	Tailpipe (SCR-out) NO_x sensor measurement
α_{sat}	Flow and inlet NO_x normalized NO_x reduction under catalyst saturation
β	Threshold for Wald test statistic for catalyst aging detection
$\gamma(k)$	Average surface concentration of adsorbed ammonia in the sample [k] to [k+1]
Γ	Surface concentration of the total storage capacity for the catalyst (mol/m^2)
ε_χ	Error in NO_x due to ammonia cross-sensitivity
ε_η	Model structure error between saturated catalyst model and actual system
η_{sat}	NO_x reduction per time-step under catalyst saturation
ϕ_{sat}	Regression vector for saturated catalyst model
ρ	Density of the exhaust gases
σ_η	Standard deviation in NO_x
σ	Scale parameter for half-normal distribution
θ_{sat}	Parameter vector for saturated catalyst model
θ_{sat}^{dg}	Parameter estimates for degreened catalyst
χ	Cross-sensitivity factor

Abbreviations:

ASC	Ammonia Slip Catalyst
CSTR	Continuously Stirred Tank Reactor
DG	Degreened
FTP	Federal Test Procedure
MLE	Maximum Likelihood Estimate
PDF	Probability Density Function
PFR	Plug Flow Reactor
RMC	Ramped Mode Cycle
SCR	Selective Catalytic Reduction

Appendix A. MAXIMUM LIKELIHOOD ESTIMATE DERIVATION

Consider,

$$\varepsilon_\eta(k) = \eta_{sat}(k) - \eta\,(k) \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \varepsilon_\eta(k) = \left(\phi_{sat}^T \theta_{sat} - \eta\,(k)\right) \tag{A.1}$$

based on the measurement sensors. Assuming ε_η follows half-normal distribution (Byers, 2014) with scale-parameter, σ,

$$\varepsilon_\eta \backsim \text{Half-Normal}(\sigma); \quad p(\varepsilon_\eta;\sigma) = \begin{cases} \dfrac{\sqrt{2}}{\sigma\sqrt{\pi}} e^{-\frac{\varepsilon_\eta^2}{2\sigma^2}} & \varepsilon_\eta \geq 0 \\ 0 & \varepsilon_\eta < 0 \end{cases} \tag{A.2}$$

we have the likelihood and log-likelihood functions given the data and parameter estimate θ_{sat} and σ:

$$l\,(\theta_{sat}) = p(\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_\eta;\theta_{sat},\sigma) = \prod_{k=1}^{N} \frac{\sqrt{2}}{\sigma\sqrt{\pi}} e^{-\frac{\varepsilon_\eta^2}{2\sigma^2}} \quad \varepsilon_\eta(k) \geq 0 \tag{A.3}$$

$$L\,(\theta_{sat}) = \ln\left(l(\theta_{sat})\right) = \frac{N}{2}\ln\frac{2}{\sigma^2\pi} - \frac{1}{2\sigma^2}\sum_{k=1}^{N}\varepsilon_\eta^2 \quad \varepsilon_\eta(k) \geq 0 \tag{A.4}$$

where N is the total sample size. The maximum likelihood estimate for θ_{sat} would be:

$$\begin{aligned} \hat{\theta}_{sat} &= \arg\max_{\theta_{sat}} \left\{ \frac{N}{2}\ln\frac{2}{\sigma^2\pi} - \frac{1}{2\sigma^2}\sum_{k=1}^{N}\varepsilon_\eta^2 \right\} \quad \varepsilon_\eta(k) \geq 0 \\ &= \arg\min_{\theta_{sat}} \left(\sum_{k=1}^{N} \varepsilon_\eta^2 \right) \quad \varepsilon_\eta(k) \geq 0 \\ &= \arg\min_{\theta_{sat}} \left(\sum_{k=1}^{N} \left(\phi_{sat}(k)^T\theta_{sat} - \eta(k)\right)^2 \right) \\ &\quad s.t \quad \phi_{sat}(k)^T\theta_{sat} \geq \eta(k) \quad \forall\, k \in 1,2,\ldots,N \end{aligned} \tag{A.5}$$

The quadratic program with a positivity constraint can be relaxed to a linear program as follows. By norm

equivalence, the l_2-norm in (A.5) is replaced with the l_1-norm, and the nonnegativity constraint renders the absolute value redundant, yielding the linear programming formulation in (A.6).

$$\hat{\theta}_{sat} = \arg\min_{\theta_{sat}} \left(\sum_{k=1}^{N} \left(\phi_{sat}(k)^T \theta_{sat} \right) \right)$$
$$s.t \quad \phi_{sat}(k)^T \theta_{sat} \geq \eta(k) \quad \forall\, k \in 1, 2, \ldots, N \quad \text{(A.6)}$$

Appendix B. LIMITATION: PARAMETER ESTIMATION ASSUMES CATALYST SATURATION

The catalyst mode detection algorithm presented fails when the catalyst is not saturated for a significant length of time in the data. If the data set does not have any regions of saturation, the approach fits a saturated model as if the maximum achieved catalyst ammonia storage, $(\max(\sigma(k)))$, is the storage capacity of the catalyst (Γ). This is demonstrated using data from high-fidelity simulation model (AVL Cruise (AVL List GmbH, 2025)) tuned to RMC (Ramped Mode Cycle) test on a test-cell. The RMC test is then simulated with ±20% change in the gain of the urea-dosing controller to change the duration for which the catalyst remains saturated. Figure-B.1 shows the

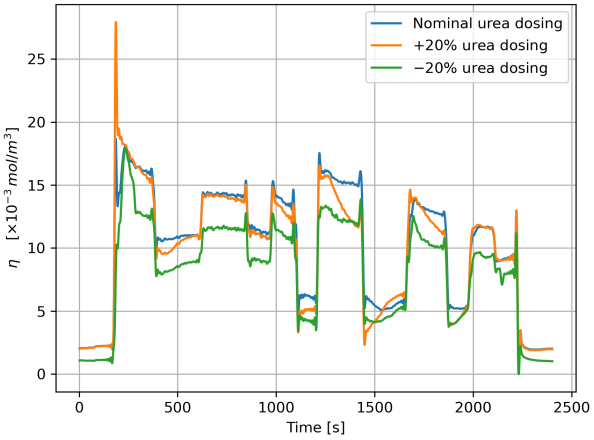


Fig. B.1. RMC η simulation with ±20% Urea Dosing

actual NO_x reduction (η) from the simulation under the three dosing conditions, while Figure-B.2 shows the corresponding predicted saturated-model response (η_{sat}) using parameters estimated from each case. Figure-B.1 shows no increase in NO_x reduction when urea dosing is increased by 20%, which indicates that maximum NO_x reduction is already reached at nominal urea dosing. This could be because the catalyst is saturated or because the inlet NO_x concentration is sufficiently low. Conversely, a 20% decrease in urea dosing decreases NO_x reduction. When the −20% urea-dosing data are used to estimate saturated-model parameters, the model predicts a substantially lower NO_x reduction under saturation than for the nominal and +20% dosing cases (Figure-B.2), the latter two giving essentially identical results. Thus, for the nominal and +20% dosing cases, the catalyst is indeed saturated, and the parameter estimates show the same. However, for the −20% dosing case, the catalyst is not saturated in the data;

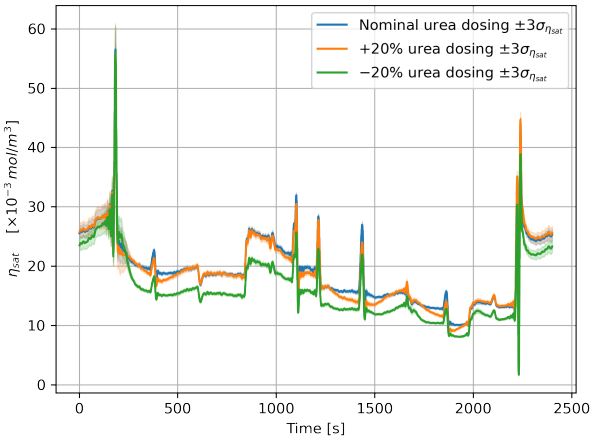


Fig. B.2. RMC η_{sat} prediction with ±20% Urea Dosing

instead, the parameters fit the maximum surface coverage achieved $\{\theta_{max} = \gamma_{max}/\Gamma\}$ in the data, i.e.,

$$\eta_{sat}(k+1) = \frac{u_1(k)}{F(k)} \tau_0 \; k_{scr} \Gamma \theta_{max} = \phi_{sat} \theta_{sat} \qquad \text{(B.1)}$$

It is assumed that under ordinary drive conditions, the catalyst will reach saturation for a significant length of time, making the proposed parameter estimation approach applicable.

Appendix C. AGING DETECTOR RESULTS ON TRUCK DATA DRIVE SEGMENTS

The value of the Wald test statistic for each drive segment that met the necessary condition of sufficient samples close to catalyst saturation is calculated and tabulated in Tables C.1, C.2, C.3 and, C.4 for Trucks A, B, C, and D, respectively. The number and percentage of samples close to catalyst saturation in each drive segment is also tabulated. There is a strong correlation between aging detection and the number of samples close to catalyst saturation in the drive segment. In each table, the entries above the horizontal rule correspond to the earlier data year and those below correspond to the latter data year (Table 6).

Table C.1. Aging Detection in Truck A

Drive Segment	T_w	N_{sat}	% (N_{sat}/N)
A_15_0	0.00	797	6.70
A_15_1	28.95	305	2.75
A_15_2	58.50	276	5.93
A_15_3	89.56	271	12.77
A_17_0	65.59	414	2.97
A_17_1	127.79	614	6.76
A_17_2	12.13	330	8.44
A_17_3	61.76	336	9.73

Table C.2. Aging Detection in Truck B

Drive Segment	T_w	N_{sat}	$\%\,(N_{sat}/N)$
B_15_0	672.43	167	1.26
B_15_1	106.66	189	1.81
B_15_3	237.79	159	2.95
B_15_4	0.00	226	6.03
B_15_6	84.73	179	5.75
B_18_0	543.55	231	2.10
B_18_1	1050.24	308	3.00
B_18_4	22.48	195	6.14
B_18_6	7150.19	378	12.73
B_18_7	760.89	224	8.14
B_18_8	342.67	246	9.04

Table C.3. Aging Detection in Truck C

Drive Segment	T_w	N_{sat}	$\%\,(N_{sat}/N)$
C_15_1	0.000	186	1.30
C_15_4	113.86	143	3.84
C_15_5	4340.08	124	4.16
C_17_0	700.88	186	1.24
C_17_2	3993.85	446	7.23
C_17_3	1693.49	199	4.00
C_17_4	186.64	120	2.81
C_17_7	1878.52	129	4.73
C_17_9	7500.10	218	11.63

Table C.4. Aging Detection in Truck D

Drive Segment	T_w	N_{sat}	$\%\,(N_{sat}/N)$
D_15_0	0.00	214	1.29
D_15_2	98.99	160	2.95
D_15_4	1546.55	213	4.90
D_15_6	935.05	152	8.86
D_16_1	423.20	246	3.67
D_16_2	1022.06	199	5.22
D_16_3	697.78	170	5.36
D_16_5	313.62	200	9.31

REFERENCES

AVL List GmbH (2025). AVL CRUISE M. Technical report, AVL List GmbH, Graz, Austria. URL `https://www.avl.com/en/simulation-solutions/simulation-software/avl-cruise-m`.

Byers, R. (2014). Half-normal distribution. *Wiley StatsRef: Statistics Reference Online*.

Charla, S., Meckl, P.H., and Yao, B. (2024). Reduced order linear modelling and identification for diesel engine scr-asc system diagnostics. *IFAC-PapersOnLine*, 58(28), 168–173.

Ciardelli, C., Nova, I., Tronconi, E., Konrad, B., Chatterjee, D., Ecke, K., and Weibel, M. (2004). Scr-denox for diesel engine exhaust aftertreatment: unsteady-state kinetic study and monolith reactor modelling. *Chemical Engineering Science*, 59(22-23), 5301–5309.

Devarakonda, M., Parker, G., Johnson, J.H., Strots, V., and Santhanam, S. (2008). Adequacy of reduced order models for model-based control in a urea-scr aftertreatment system. Technical report, SAE Technical Paper.

Devarakonda, M., Parker, G., Johnson, J.H., Strots, V., and Santhanam, S. (2009). Model-based estimation and control system development in a urea-scr aftertreatment system. *SAE International Journal of Fuels and Lubricants*, 1(1), 646–661.

Hsieh, M.F. and Wang, J. (2011). Development and experimental studies of a control-oriented scr model for a two-catalyst urea-scr system. *Control Engineering Practice*, 19(4), 409–422.

Hsieh, M.F. and Wang, J. (2014). *Urea-SCR technology for deNOx after treatment of diesel exhaust, Chapter-14: Diesel Engine SCR Systems: Modelling, Measurements, and Control*, volume 5. Springer.

Jain, K.K., Hiremath, J.R., and Meckl, P.H. (2020). Term-by-term observer design method to estimate nh 3 storage in scr catalyst. In *2020 American Control Conference (ACC)*, 4899–4904. IEEE.

Jain, K.K., Meckl, P., Chen, P., and Yang, K. (2023). Diagnostics-oriented model for automotive scr-asc. *International Journal of Prognostics and Health Management*, 14(3).

Jiang, K., Yan, F., and Zhang, H. (2019). Hydrothermal aging factor estimation for two-cell diesel-engine scr systems via a dual time-scale unscented kalman filter. *IEEE Transactions on Industrial Electronics*, 67(1), 442–450.

Joo, K., Jo, J.H., Kim, C., Lee, J.h., and Kim, H.j. (2008). The study of nox reduction using urea-scr system with cpf and doc for light duty vehicle; the diesel nox reduction system. Technical report, SAE Technical Paper.

Kay, S.M. (1993). *Fundamentals of statistical signal processing: estimation theory*. Prentice-Hall, Inc.

Kay, S.M. (1998). *Fundamentals of statistical signal processing: detection theory*. Prentice-Hall, Inc.

Ma, Y. and Wang, J. (2017). Observer-based estimation of aging condition for selective catalytic reduction systems in vehicle applications. *Journal of Dynamic Systems, Measurement, and Control*, 139(2), 021002.

Matsumoto, A., Furui, K., Ogiso, M., and Kidokoro, T. (2016). Model-based obd logic utilizing adsorption and desorption model of nh 3 in scr catalyst. Technical report, SAE Technical Paper.

Press, W.H., Teukolsky, S.A., Vettering, W.T., and Flannery, B.P. (2003). Numerical recipes in c++: The art of scientific computing (2nd edn). *European Journal of Physics*, 24(3), 329–330.

Prins, R. (2018). Eley–rideal, the other mechanism. *Topics in Catalysis*, 61(9), 714–721.

Trefethen, L.N. (2019). *Approximation theory and approximation practice, extended edition*. SIAM.

Trump, T. (2001). Maximum likelihood trend estimation in exponential noise. *IEEE Transactions on Signal Processing*, 49(9), 2087–2095. doi:10.1109/78.942636.

Wald, A. (1943). Tests of statistical hypotheses concerning several parameters when the number of observations is large. *Transactions of the American Mathematical society*, 54(3), 426–482.

Yuan, X., Liu, H., and Gao, Y. (2015). Diesel engine scr control: current development and future challenges. *Emission Control Science and Technology*, 1, 121–133.